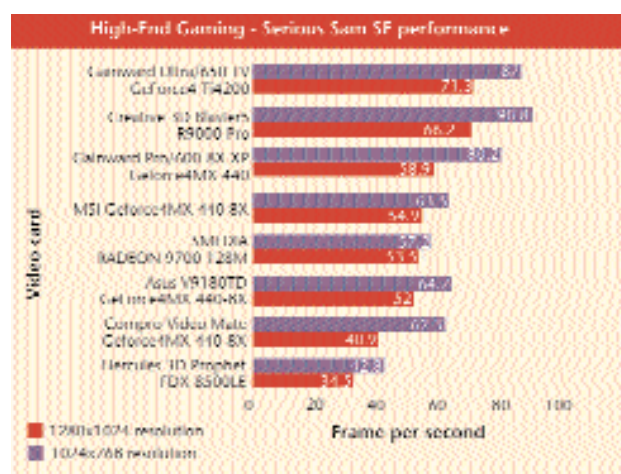
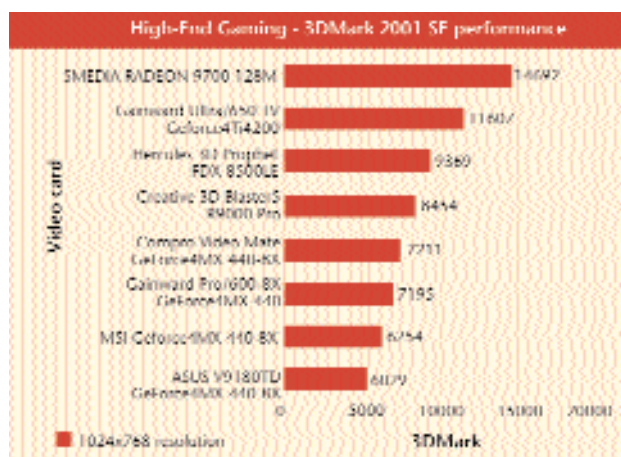




favour. Indeed, as pointed earlier, cards based on the ATI Radeon came out tops. Of all tests of notable weightage, these cards lost only once to their rival, the Gainward Ultra/650 TV running on the GeForce4Ti4200 chipset—the test in question being the *Serious Sam* game at a 1280x1024 resolution.

The Gainward scored 71.3 fps, an amazing showing when compared to its nearest competitor, the R9000 Pro-based Creative 3D BLASTER5 (with 66.2 fps). Memory bandwidth-saving technologies such as a faster Z buffer-clear, an efficient memory chip layout and better compression algorithms, allowed the ATI-chipset-based cards to perform very well under high-resolutions. Thus, the 3DMark2001 SE crown at 1024x768 was taken by the efficient and DirectX 9.0 compatible SMEDIA RADEON 9700. The practical application of which shone under the *UT 2003* test, as this particular card managed to stay above the 60 fps mark even at 1280x1024 with a score of 65.87 fps.

Of special mention is the COMPRO VideoMate Cinema. Based on the GeForce4 MX 440 chipset, it bundles together a set-top box that acts as a TV Tuner. You can thus enjoy your favourite TV programmes on your PC and with the help of the right software, you could even record and playback some of your favourite shows and events at the cost of hard disk space. (For more information on how to use such a video card as a personal video recorder, see 'Your PC as a VCR' in the December 2002 issue of *Digit*.) The card in question costs Rs 11,995, which is significantly more than the ASUS or the MSI versions, undoubtedly due to the TV Tuner card.

The Matrox Parhelia also deserves a mention, thanks due